

Office of the
PRESIDENT AND VICE-CHANCELLOR

July 28, 2020

Dr. Mark Mercer
President, Society for Academic Freedom and Scholarship
6593, rue Jeann-Mance
Montreal (Qc) H2V 4L1

Dear Dr. Mercer,

Thank you for your letter of July 27, 2020 regarding the important issue of academic freedom.

As indicated in Thompson Rivers University's recent public statement in response to the inquiries regarding Dr. Pyne, TRU fully supports the exercise of academic freedom. Academic freedom, including the ability to conduct independent research, freely communicate knowledge and the results of research and scholarship, and respectfully debate differences, is core to our university culture.

Universities provide significant employment protection for faculty members which is intrinsically tied to them being able to exercise academic freedom. At TRU, this protection is included in our collective agreements with faculty, and includes the freedom to criticize the university. As such, in situations where faculty members have faced discipline, it is not about their academic freedom but rather other issues that have arisen in the workplace.

Privacy laws prevent organizations from releasing information about a specific individual. As a result, we will not be releasing information specifically related to Dr. Pyne. Matters involving Dr. Pyne do not pertain to exercise of academic freedom.

Any and all suspensions at TRU follow thorough, careful, and due processes. Often these processes take months or even years and include numerous meetings with employees and union representatives as well as external investigations where needed. Progressive discipline follows steps and procedures mandated in collective agreements and employees are informed in detail and in writing about the reasons for any disciplinary action. Employees have various avenues for appeals on employment matters and are accompanied and supported by their union, which is accountable to the BC Labour Relations Board. Decisions of the latter are a matter of public record.

I appreciate you reaching out to me about academic freedom in Canada.

Sincerely,



BRETT FAIRBAIRN
President and Vice-Chancellor

Cc: Monica Sanchez-Flores, President, Thompson Rivers University Faculty Association